stock market of the 1950s than at any time before or since. This taught me not only that it's difficult to predict markets, but also that small investors tend to be pessimistic and optimistic at precisely the wrong times, so it's self-defeating to try to invest in good markets and get out of bad ones.

My father, an industrious man and former mathematics professor who left academia to become the youngest senior auditor at John Hancock, got sick when I was seven and died of brain cancer when I was ten. This tragedy resulted in my mother's having to go to work (at Ludlow Manufacturing, later acquired by Tyco Labs), and I decided to help out by getting a part-time job myself. At the age of eleven I was hired as a caddy. That was on July 7, 1955, a day the Dow Jones fell from 467 to 460.

To an eleven-year-old who'd already discovered golf, caddying was an ideal occupation. They paid me for walking around a golf course. In one afternoon I would outearn delivery boys who tossed newspapers onto lawns at six A.M. for seven days in a row. What could be better than that?

In high school I began to understand the subtler and more important advantages of caddying, especially at an exclusive club such as Brae Burn, outside of Boston. My clients were the presidents and CEOs of major corporations: Gillette, Polaroid, and more to the point, Fidelity. In helping D. George Sullivan find his ball, I was helping myself find a career. I'm not the only caddy who learned that the quickest route to the boardroom was through the locker room of a club like Brae Burn.

If you wanted an education in stocks, the golf course was the next best thing to being on the floor of a major exchange. Especially after they'd sliced or hooked a drive, club members enthusiastically described their latest triumphant investment. In a single round of play I might give out five golf tips and get back five stock tips in return.

Though I had no funds to invest in stock tips, the happy stories I heard on the fairways made me rethink the family position that the stock market was a place to lose money. Many of my clients actually seemed to have made money in the stock market, and some of the positive evidence actually trickled down to me.

A caddy quickly learns to sort his golfers into a caste system, beginning with the rare demigods (great golfer, great person, great tipper), moving down through the so-so golfers and so-so tippers, and eventually hitting bottom with the terrible golfer, terrible person, terrible tipper—a dreaded untouchable of the links. Mostly I caddied for average golfers and average spenders, but if it came down to a choice between a bad round with a big tipper, or a great round with a bad tipper, I learned to opt for the former. Caddying reinforced the notion that it helps to have money.